

LinguaLounge IPA Reference Sheet: French

Base language: English - / / = broad phonemic IPA, [] = common phonetic realization.
Regional pronunciation can vary.

Scope

Standard Metropolitan French. Nasal vowels and the /ɛ/ - /e/ distinction can vary by region and speaker.

VOWELS

Category	IPA symbols
Oral vowels	/i y u e ø œ ɛ æ ɔ a/
Nasal vowels	/ã ɛ̃ ɔ̃ œ̃/
Glides	/j ɥ w/

CONSONANTS

Category	IPA symbols
Plosives	/p b t d k g/
Fricatives	/f v s z ʃ ʒ ʁ/
Nasals	/m n ɲ ŋ/
Liquids / glides	/l ʝ ɥ w/

ALPHABET AND COMMON SPELLING VALUES

The table gives common learner-safe values. Some letters have additional values in loanwords, names, or regional speech.

Letter / spelling	Main IPA value	Example	Notes
A a	/a/	ami /a.mi/	
B b	/b/	bon /bɔ̃/	
C c	/s/ or /k/	ceci /sə.si/, car /kaʁ/	Before e/i/y -> /s/; otherwise usually /k/.
Ç ç	/s/	français /fʁɑ̃.sɛ/	Used before a/o/u to keep /s/.
D d	/d/	deux /dø/	Often silent word-finally.
E e	/ə, e, ɛ/	le /lə/, été /e.te/, mère /mɛʁ/	Highly spelling- and position-dependent.
F f	/f/	femme /fam/	
G g	/ʒ/ or /g/	genre /ʒɑ̃ʁ/, gare /gaʁ/	Before e/i/y -> /ʒ/; otherwise /g/.
Gn gn	/ɲ/	montagne /mɔ̃.taɲ/	
H h	silent	homme /ɔ̃m/	h has no sound; h aspiré can block liaison.
I i	/i/	ici /i.si/	
J j	/ʒ/	jour /ʒuʁ/	
K k	/k/	kilo /ki.lo/	Mostly loanwords.
L l	/l/	lune /lyn/	
M m	/m/	mère /mɛʁ/	After vowels, m/n often mark nasal vowels.
N n	/n/	nuit /nuj/	After vowels, n/m often mark nasal vowels.
O o	/o, ɔ/	eau /o/, homme /ɔ̃m/	
P p	/p/	Paris /pa.ʁi/	ph = /f/: photo /fo.to/.
Q q	/k/	qui /ki/	Usually qu = /k/.
R r	/ʁ/	rue /ʁy/	
S s	/s/ or /z/	sac /sak/, rose /ʁoz/	Between vowels often /z/.
T t	/t/ or /s/	terre /tɛʁ/, nation /na.sjɔ̃/	-tion is often /sjɔ̃/.
U u	/y/	tu /ty/	ou = /u/: vous /vu/.
V v	/v/	vin /vɛ̃/	
W w	/v/ or /w/	wagon /va.gɔ̃/, week-end /wi.kɑ̃d/	Loanword-dependent.
X x	/ks/ or /gz/	taxi /tak.si/, examen /ɛg.za.mɛ̃/	
Y y	/i/ or /j/	style /stil/, yoga /jɔ̃.ga/	
Z z	/z/	zéro /ze.ʁo/	

IMPORTANT SPELLING AND PRONUNCIATION NOTES

Nasal vowels	an/en = /ɑ̃/, in/ain/ein = /ɛ̃/, on = /ɔ̃/, un = /œ̃/ for speakers who keep it distinct.
Final consonants	Many final consonants are silent: petit /pə.ti/. They may reappear in liaison: les amis /le.z_a.mi/.

Accents	é usually marks /e/; è/ê often mark /ɛ/. Accents can also distinguish spelling and meaning.
Stress	French stress normally falls on the final pronounced syllable of a phrase, not on every individual word.